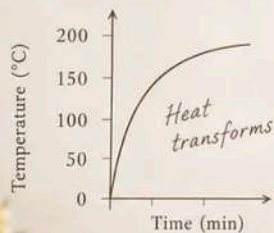


FLOUR
HEAT
TIME
TRANSFORMATION
A HAPPIER YOU



Real Food
Real Science
A Brighter You

THE PHYSICS OF BAKING

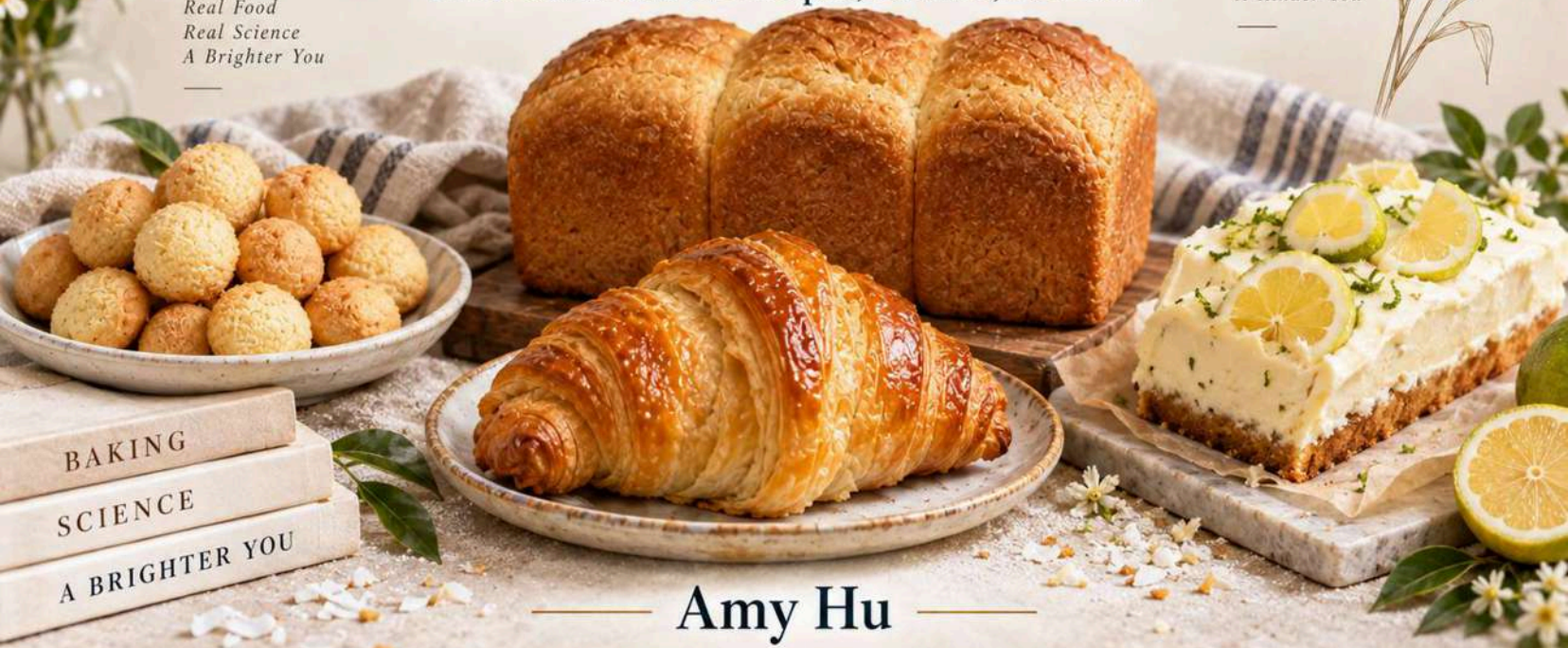
Twelve Months of Recipes, Science, and Self

GOOD
FOOD
BRIGHTER
DAYS

$$Q = mc\Delta T$$

Small
Molecules
Big Changes

Better
Baking
A Kinder You



Amy Hu

The Physics of Baking

Twelve Months of Recipes, Science, and Self



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*Good food
builds brighter days.*



GOOD
FOOD
BRIGHTER
PEOPLE



Dedication



For my grandfather, whose hearing challenges
first taught me to notice the quiet details
of everyday life;

for my family, who filled our kitchen
with patience and warmth;

and for every curious baker who has ever found
science hidden in a whisk, a rise,
or a golden crust.



SMALL DETAILS
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW



WELCOME

A Year of Recipes, Science, and Self

Baking has always been more than just food to me. It is a way of exploring the world — where simple ingredients transform through science, where patience turns into something beautiful, and where every small success builds a kinder, more curious version of myself.

This book brings together twelve months of recipes, the science behind them, and the personal stories that make baking meaningful. May it inspire you to bake, to learn, and to find a little more sweetness in your own everyday life.

*Good food
brings brighter days*
♥



Little bakes, big joy ♥



Work in progress ♥



From my kitchen ♥

WHAT YOU'LL FIND



12 Monthly Recipes

From cozy bakes to festive treats, each month brings a new recipe, a story, and a little kitchen inspiration.



The Science Behind the Bake

Clear, friendly explanations of the “why” — the small molecules and big ideas that make baking magic happen.



Personal Reflections

Thoughts, lessons, and moments from my baking journey — about patience, creativity, and finding joy in the process.



More Than Just Food

A celebration of curiosity, mindfulness, and a sweeter, more intentional life.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1

Browse by the Months

Follow the calendar or jump to whatever you're in the mood to bake. Each recipe stands on its own.

2

Read, Then Bake (or Vice Versa)

You can dive into the science first, or start with the recipe. Both paths lead to delicious discoveries.

3

Make It Your Own

Use these recipes as a guide, and feel free to adapt, experiment, and add your personal touch. That's how learning (and baking) grows.

4

Take Your Time

Baking isn't just about the destination — it's about the slower, kinder rhythm in between. Enjoy the process.

THE PHYSICS OF BAKING

*Twelve Months
of Recipes,
Science, and Self*
♥

*Same
simple
ingredients.
Brighter
days.*
♥

*A CALMER
MIND
A KINDER YOU
A BRIGHTER
TOMORROW*
♥

*GOOD FOOD
BRIGHTER DAYS*

Introduction

TWELVE MONTHS. TWELVE RECIPES.
A DEEPER CONNECTION.

This book is an invitation to slow down, look closer, and find extraordinary meaning in the everyday act of baking. Across twelve months, you'll find twelve carefully chosen recipes, each paired with a personal identity theme — a gentle prompt to reflect, grow, and connect — and a physics concept that reveals the hidden science working in your kitchen. Together, they show how the simple act of making something delicious can nourish not just the body, but also the mind and the heart.

Baking is both emotional and analytical. It fills our homes with comforting aromas, evokes cherished memories, and brings people together. At the same time, it is a precise dance of heat, molecules, and time. A cake rises because gases expand, a custard sets because proteins link together, bread develops character through fermentation, and a silky texture comes from carefully balanced emulsions. These are not just kitchen tricks — they are the same principles that shape the world around us.

By exploring familiar, accessible recipes, this book shows that home baking can be a lens for learning. You'll discover how heat transfer creates a golden crust, how protein coagulation transforms liquid into structure, how fermentation brings life and flavor, how emulsions create smoothness, and how texture emerges from microscopic changes. Each recipe is a small experiment, a chance to see science in action, and a reminder that curiosity makes everything taste a little sweeter.

The kitchen is more than a place to follow instructions — it is a place where science becomes visible, edible, and personal. Here, knowledge is not confined to textbooks; it rises in the oven, bubbles in a pan, and melts on your tongue. May these pages inspire you to bake with a little more wonder, a little more intention, and a deeper appreciation for the beautiful physics in every bite.

“*In every rise,
crumble, and
caramelized edge,
there is both
memory and method.*”

GOOD
RECIPES
BRIGHTER
PEOPLE
KINDER
TOMORROWS



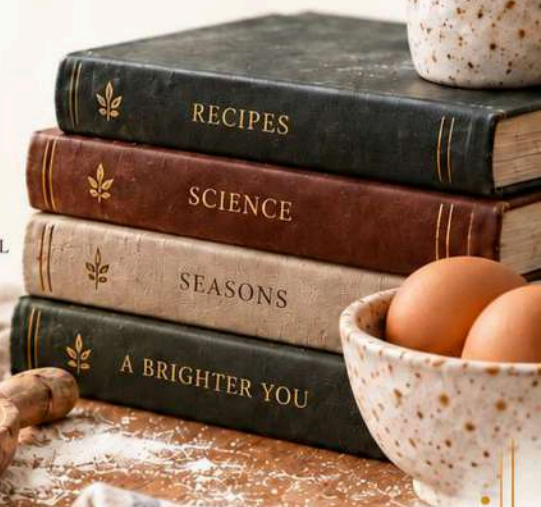
FAMILIAR
RECIPES



REAL
SCIENCE



A MORE
THOUGHTFUL
YOU



How to Read This Book

RECIPES. SCIENCE. A BRIGHTER YOU.

Good food is a journey — and this book is your companion. ♥

SIMPLE
INGREDIENTS
BRIGHTER DAYS
KINDER YOU

1 Monthly Recipe Page

A RECIPE. A SEASON. A GENTLER YOU.

Each month opens with a beautiful recipe page, featuring a seasonal bake, engaging introduction, clear ingredients and method, and a real kitchen photograph.

AUGUST Precision

Month & identity theme

A warm introduction to the month's theme

Same simple things. Even better results.

Clear ingredients list

INGREDIENTS

For the pastry (pâte sucrée)

- 250 g plain flour (all-purpose flour)
- 125 g unsalted butter, cold and cubed
- 80 g icing sugar (confectioners' sugar)
- 1 large egg yolk
- 1-2 tbsp ice-cold water
- A pinch of salt

For the egg custard filling

- 500 ml whole milk
- 300 ml double cream (heavy cream)
- 150 g caster sugar
- 3 large egg yolks
- 1 tablespoon cornflour (cornstarch)
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract (or 1 vanilla bean)
- A pinch of salt

METHOD

- 1 Make the pastry.** In a bowl, rub the butter into the flour and icing sugar until it resembles fine crumbs. Add the egg yolk, salt and cold water, and bring together into a smooth dough. Wrap and rest for 30 mins.
- 2 Roll out the tart cases.** Roll out the chilled dough, cut into rounds and line a tart tin. Prick the base with a fork and chill for 30 mins while the oven heats to 190°C/170°C fan/Gas 5.
- 3 Blind bake.** Line the cases with baking parchment and fill with baking beans. Bake for 10 mins, remove the paper and beans, then bake for 5-7 mins until pale golden.
- 4 Make the custard.** In a saucepan, gently heat the milk and cream until just simmering. In a bowl, whisk together egg yolks, sugar, cornflour and vanilla. Slowly whisk the warm milk into the yolks, then return to the pan and cook gently until slightly thickened. Remove from the heat.
- 5 Fill and bake.** Strain the custard into the cooled pastry cases. Bake at 190°C/170°C fan/Gas 5 for 15-18 mins, until the tops are lightly caramelized with a few dark fleckles.
- 6 Cool and enjoy.** Let the tarts cool completely before serving. Best enjoyed slightly warm or at room temperature.

SMALL DETAILS BRIGHTER DAYS A KINDER YOU



A real kitchen photograph

A personal touch

Step-by-step method with clear guidance

2 Physics Page

SIMPLE SCIENCE. BIGGER FLAVOUR.

Turn the page to discover the science behind the bake. Each physics page has four focused modules, with clear diagrams, explanations and a practical kitchen takeaway.



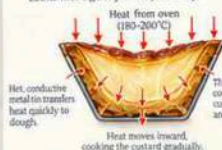
REAL SCIENCE
BETTER BAKES
BRIGHTER DAYS

AUGUST The Physics of French Egg Tarts

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

1 Heat Transfer Bakes from the Outside In

Heat flows from hot air and the metal tin into the tart shell and custard. The crust sets first, giving structure, while the center cooks more gently to stay creamy.

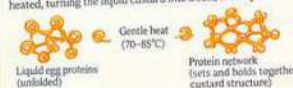


Golden top from gentle caramelisation

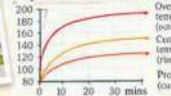


2 Protein Coagulation Sets the Custard

Egg proteins denature (unfold) and link together when heated, turning the liquid custard into a soft, creamy set.



Temperature Profile While Baking



The custard sets gently, preventing cracking and creating a silky texture.

3 Caramelization and Browning Create the Signature Top

High heat at the surface triggers caramelization of sugars and Maillard reactions between sugars and proteins, giving egg tarts their beautiful colour and flavour.



Deep golden colour = flavour compounds



SURFACE COLOUR DEVELOPS OVER TIME

Maillard reactions create hundreds of flavour molecules as the sugars and proteins cook.

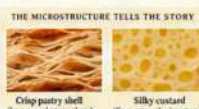
Higher oven temperatures create more caramelisation, bringing the classic dark, roasted top.

4 Texture Contrast Makes It Irresistible

The high fat content creates a rich, tender custard, while the starch helps it set to a smooth, silky texture — a perfect contrast with the crisp pastry shell.



Crisp, buttery pastry shell



THE TAKEAWAY

- Use a hot oven (180°C/170°C fan) to set the pastry and develop flavour.
- Let the custard cool slowly for the best texture.
- A balance of heat, time and simple ingredients creates magic.
- Look closely before eating — every tart tells a science story!

Good science makes life a little sweeter. ♥

3 Across the Year

TWELVE MONTHS. TWELVE MOODS.

Each month has a unique colour palette, reflecting the season and its identity theme — from fresh new beginnings to cozy reflection. Together they create a year of flavour, learning and gentle growth.

1 JAN Renewal	2 FEB Connection	3 MAR Courage	4 APR Balance	5 MAY Growth	6 JUN Joy
7 JUL Freedom	8 AUG Precision	9 SEP Restraint	10 OCT Gratitude	11 NOV Comfort	12 DEC Hope

4 What to Look For

KEY ELEMENTS IN EVERY RECIPE AND SCIENCE PAGE.

- Texture**
Crisp, soft, chewy, airy — feel the difference.
- Temperature**
Heat changes everything.
- Structure**
From simple ingredients to beautiful results.
- Time**
Patience brings flavour.
- Transformation**
Small changes create something extraordinary.

Same simple things. A brighter year.

Good
Food
Curiosity
Kinder Days



A Note on Recipes, Physics, and Photography

SAME KITCHEN. BIGGER UNDERSTANDING.

These pages
celebrate real kitchens,
real experiments,
and real learning.



GOOD
FOOD
CURIOSITY
KINDER DAYS



A BRIGHTER
YOU

1 Recipes for Real Kitchens

All recipes in this book are adapted for the home kitchen and tested through my own baking practice. I use everyday ingredients, clear steps, and realistic methods so you can bake with confidence, whether you're a beginner or a seasoned home baker.



Simple
ingredients.
Meaningful
results.

2 Physics Made Approachable

The physics explanations are simplified and visual, designed to highlight the core concepts behind each recipe. They are not a replacement for a textbook, but rather a friendly guide to help you see the science in your everyday baking and appreciate the "why" behind the results.



Curiosity
makes everything
taste better.

3 Real Photos, Real Moments

All food photographs and framed snapshots in this book come from my actual baking process — real bakes, real kitchen moments. They are lightly color-corrected for clarity and consistency, but always true to what really happened in my kitchen. I hope these images make the journey feel personal, inviting, and achievable.



Baked.
Photographed.
Shared from
my kitchen.

4 Embrace Variation

Baking is a living, breathing process. Small variations in ingredients, temperature, humidity, or equipment can lead to slightly different results — and that's completely normal. Each bake is unique, and every attempt teaches us something new.



Different
bakes.
Same joy.



Still warm from the oven

- ✓ Same ingredients
- ✓ More understanding
- ✓ Tastier results
- ✓ Brighter days



Good food
leads to
a brighter you





JANUARY

Simplicity

January invites us to slow down and find joy in simple things. A handful of basic ingredients, a warm kitchen and a little time can create something truly special. Simplicity isn't about having less — it's about appreciating what matters most.

*Simple ingredients.
Sweeter days.*



From my kitchen ♥

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups shredded coconut
- 2 egg whites
- ½ cup sugar
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- A pinch of salt



METHOD

- 1 Whisk the egg whites lightly until slightly frothy.
- 2 Combine with sugar, shredded coconut, vanilla and a pinch of salt until well mixed.
- 3 Scoop the mixture and roll into small balls.
- 4 Bake at 170°C (340°F) for 15–20 minutes, or until lightly golden.



GOOD
THINGS
CAN BE
SIMPLE



A BRIGHTER
YEAR AHEAD

Good
food
brings
good days



The Physics of Coconut Balls

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. BEAUTIFUL SCIENCE.

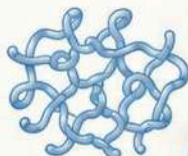
1 Egg-White Proteins Set the Structure

HEAT UNFOLDS PROTEINS, WHICH LINK TOGETHER INTO A STABLE NETWORK.



Uncooked egg-white proteins (folded)

Heat
(~60–80°C)



Denatured proteins link together (coagulate)



RESULT

A set network traps coconut, sugar and moisture, giving the macaroon its structure.

Crisp, golden surface

Soft, tender interior



Real coconut balls from our kitchen!

A balance of structure, moisture, sweetness and browning in every bite.

3 Sugar Is Hygroscopic

SUGAR BINDS WATER MOLECULES, AFFECTING TENDERNESS, CHEW AND SHELF LIFE.



Sugar molecule (attracts water)



= Water molecule



= Sugar molecule



RESULT

Sugar holds on to water, keeping the macaroons tender and chewy rather than dry and crumbly.

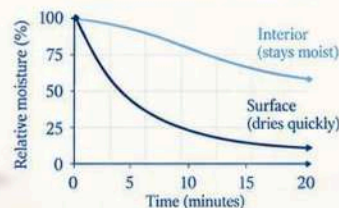
2 Moisture Evaporation Controls Texture

WATER EVAPORATES DURING BAKING, DRYING THE SURFACE FIRST AND CREATING A MOISTER INTERIOR.

Water vapor leaves surface



Moisture Loss During Baking



RESULT

Surface drying creates a crisp exterior while some moisture remains inside for a tender, chewy texture.

4 Browning Happens on the Surface

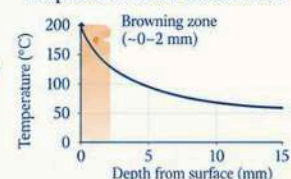
HEAT DRIVES MAILLARD REACTIONS BETWEEN SUGARS AND PROTEINS, CREATING FLAVOR AND COLOR.



Darker, crisp crust (more Maillard reactions)

Lighter interior (fewer reactions)

Temperature Inside a Coconut Ball



RESULT

Most browning occurs in the thin surface layer, where heat, sugars and proteins intensify flavor and create a golden crust.

THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Whip egg whites for better structure.
- ✓ Bake long enough to set and dry the surface, but not so long that the interior becomes dry.
- ✓ Use the right amount of sugar for tenderness and chew.
- ✓ Look for a rich golden color — it signals flavor and a perfectly baked macaroon.



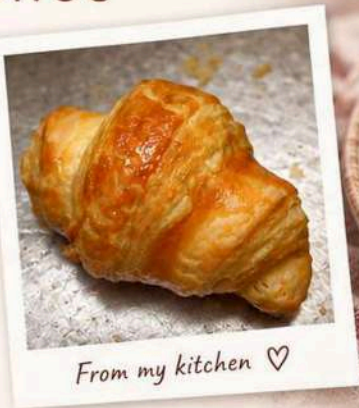
SIMPLE STEPS. SWEETER RESULTS.

FEBRUARY

Patience

February reminds us that beautiful things take time. A croissant is more than a pastry — it's a lesson in patience, in small, repeated actions that create extraordinary results. Layer by layer, time transforms simple ingredients into something light, flaky, and full of possibility. Like the croissant, our own growth often happens in the quiet folds.

GOOD THINGS
TAKE TIME.



From my kitchen ♥



LAYERED
MOMENTS
BRIGHTER
DAYS.



INGREDIENTS

500 g bread flour (high protein)
250 ml cold milk
7 g active dry yeast (or 21 g fresh yeast)
50 g granulated sugar
10 g salt
250 g unsalted butter (for dough)
250 g unsalted butter (for lamination)

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS
EXTRAORDINARY POSSIBILITIES



METHOD

- 1 Make the detrempe.** Combine flour, milk, yeast, sugar, salt, and 250 g butter. Mix until a smooth dough forms. Knead briefly, then rest for 1 hour in the refrigerator.
- 2 Prepare the butter block.** Shape 250 g cold butter into a flat rectangle (about 15 × 20 cm) between parchment paper.
- 3 Laminates.** Roll the dough into a rectangle, place the butter block in the center, fold, and seal. Roll and fold (turn) the dough 3 times, resting 30–60 minutes in the refrigerator between each turn.
- 4 Shape.** Roll the final dough, cut into triangles, and roll into croissants.
- 5 Proof.** Place on a baking sheet and let rise at room temperature for 2–3 hours, until puffy and airy.
- 6 Bake.** Brush with egg wash and bake at 200°C (390°F) for 18–22 minutes, until deep golden brown.

FOOD FOR A
BRIGHTER YEAR

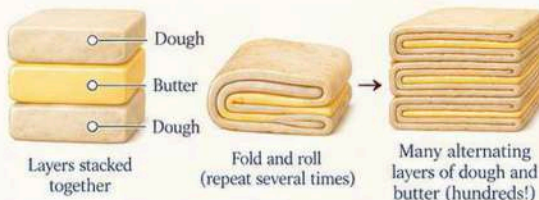


The Physics of Croissants

LAYERS OF SCIENCE. MOMENTS OF JOY.

1 Lamination Creates Layers

THIN LAYERS OF DOUGH AND BUTTER BUILD HUNDREDS OF FLAKY SHEETS.

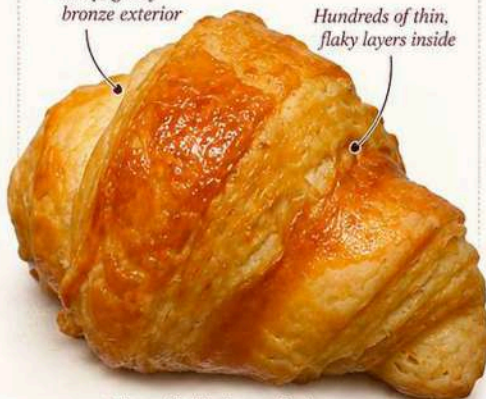


RESULT

Repeated folding (lamination) creates many thin layers, which separate in the oven to form a light, flaky, airy structure.

Crisp, glossy bronze exterior

Hundreds of thin, flaky layers inside



A beautiful balance of crispness, softness, and air — all built through physics.

2 Butter Plasticity Matters

BUTTER MUST BE COOL AND PLIABLE SO IT STAYS IN LAYERS RATHER THAN MIXING INTO THE DOUGH.

Too cold
(below 12°C / 54°F)



Butter is hard and brittle, cracks during rolling, creating uneven layers.

Just right
(12–16°C / 54–61°F)



Pliable and plastic — spreads easily and stays in distinct layers.

Too warm
(above 18°C / 64°F)



Butter becomes too soft, leaks into the dough, and layers are lost.

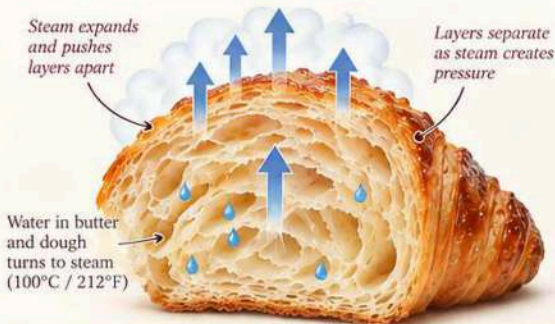


RESULT

Keeping butter cool but pliable preserves distinct layers, which is essential for flakiness.

3 Steam Drives Lift

WATER IN THE DOUGH AND BUTTER TURNS TO STEAM IN THE OVEN, PUSHING LAYERS APART.



RESULT

Expanding steam creates lift, separating the layers and giving croissants their airy, open crumb.

FROM MY KITCHEN



The real croissant (lightly color-corrected)

THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Rest the dough between folds so gluten can relax.
- ✓ Keep butter cool but pliable (about 12–16°C / 54–61°F).
- ✓ Use even, gentle folds to create consistent layers.
- ✓ Proof fully before baking to allow for maximum lift and flakiness.

PATIENCE TURNS INGREDIENTS INTO SOMETHING EXTRAORDINARY.

4 Gluten Relaxation and Proofing

RESTING RELAXES GLUTEN, MAKING THE DOUGH EASIER TO ROLL, WHILE YEAST CREATES GAS THAT ADDS VOLUME.



Before resting (tight gluten)



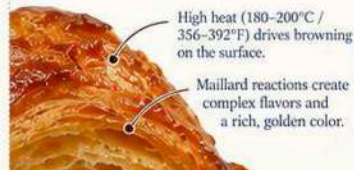
After resting (relaxed, extensible)



After proofing (increased volume from yeast gas)

5 Browning Brings Flavor

HEAT TRANSFERS INTO THE CROISSANT, DRIVING MAILLARD REACTIONS THAT CREATE A DEEP GOLDEN CRUST.



RESULT

A golden, crispy crust forms, adding flavor, contrast, and that irresistible finish.

MARCH

Growth

SLOW INGREDIENTS. BIGGER TOMORROWS.

March reminds us that growth takes time. Like dough, we expand slowly, quietly, and often out of sight. With a little warmth, patience, and care, simple ingredients transform into something nourishing and beautiful. Bread teaches us that steady progress—no matter how gradual—can create something truly remarkable.

*Small steps
also rise.* ♥



Homemade, with love ♥



Little shapes, big joy.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 cups bread flour (or all-purpose flour)
- 1½ cups warm water or milk (about 110°F / 43°C)
- 2¼ tsp active dry yeast (1 packet)
- 2 Tbsp sugar
- 1½ tsp salt
- 3 Tbsp unsalted butter (softened) or olive oil
- ½ cup dried fruit (optional, e.g., raisins, cranberries)

*Simple ingredients.
A more generous you.*

METHOD

- 1 Mix**
In a large bowl, combine warm water or milk, yeast and sugar. Let sit for 5–10 minutes until foamy. Add flour, salt and butter (and dried fruit if using). Mix until a rough dough forms.
- 2 Knead**
Knead the dough on a lightly floured surface for 8–10 minutes, until smooth and elastic.
- 3 First Rise**
Place the dough in a lightly oiled bowl, cover, and let it rise in a warm spot for 1–1½ hours, or until doubled in size.
- 4 Shape**
Punch down the dough, shape it into a loaf (or rolls), and place it in a greased loaf pan or on a baking sheet.
- 5 Second Rise**
Cover and let it rise again for 30–60 minutes, until puffy.
- 6 Bake**
Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Bake for 30–35 minutes, or until golden brown and the loaf sounds hollow when tapped.

*Real
fermentation
creates real
growth—
in bread
and in us.* ♥

**GOOD
THINGS
RISE
IN TIME**

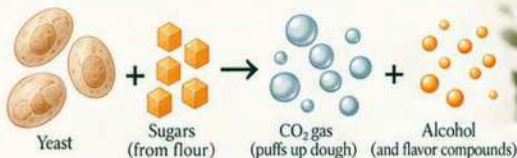
**SAME
INGREDIENTS.
A BRIGHTER YOU.**

The Physics of Bread

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. REMARKABLE TRANSFORMATIONS.

1 Yeast Fermentation Creates Gas

YEAST CONSUMES SUGARS AND PRODUCES CARBON DIOXIDE (CO_2) AND ALCOHOL.



RESULT

Carbon dioxide forms bubbles in the dough, causing it to expand and become light and airy.

Golden, flavorful crust

Soft, airy crumb inside



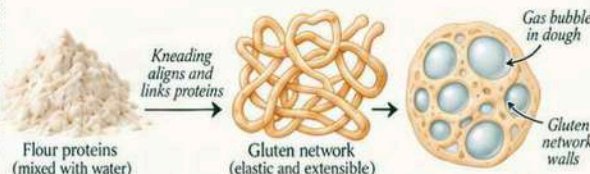
Simple ingredients. Extraordinary results.

Flour, water, time and heat work together to turn something simple into something extraordinary.



2 Gluten Network Traps the Gas

KNEADING ALIGNS FLOUR PROTEINS (GLIADIN AND GLUTENIN) INTO A STRONG, ELASTIC NETWORK THAT TRAPS GAS BUBBLES.

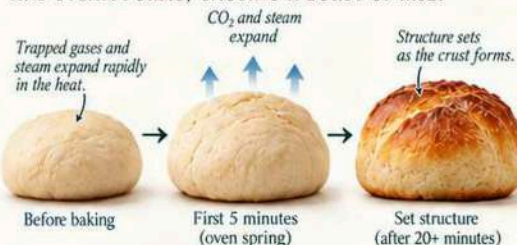


RESULT

A stretchy gluten network holds gas bubbles, allowing the dough to rise without collapsing.

3 Oven Spring Drives Rapid Expansion

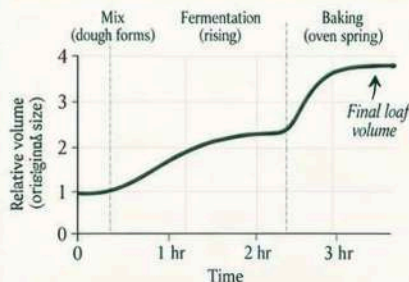
IN THE FIRST FEW MINUTES OF BAKING, GASES EXPAND AND STEAM FORMS, CAUSING A BURST OF RISE.



RESULT

Rapid expansion (oven spring) gives bread its final volume and light texture.

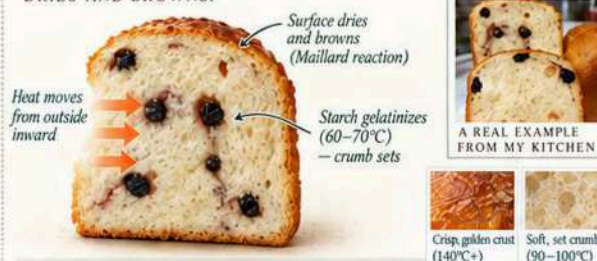
Dough Rises Over Time



Slow fermentation builds flavor.
A final burst of rise in the oven creates a light, open crumb.

4 Starch Gelatinization and Crust Formation

HEAT SETS THE STRUCTURE INSIDE WHILE THE SURFACE DRIES AND BROWNS.



A REAL EXAMPLE FROM MY KITCHEN



RESULT

The crust becomes crisp and flavorful, while starch gelatinization sets the soft, tender interior.



IN THE KITCHEN: THE TAKEAWAY



Knead enough to build structure (develop gluten).



Let the dough rise until puffy (give yeast time).



Bake fully for a set, light crumb.



Cool before slicing (to let the structure settle).

Good Science
Tastes Better



APRIL

Renewal

April is a reminder that every ending brings a new beginning. As days grow longer and the world turns green again, we're invited to refresh — in our kitchens and in our lives. This lemon cheesecake is a celebration of renewal: bright, creamy and full of sunshine, a little slice of hope for whatever comes next.

*New season.
Brighter flavors.
A fresh start.*



From my kitchen ♥



FRESH
INGREDIENTS
BRIGHTER
DAYS
A KINDER YOU



*Good
food
brings
brighter
days*



INGREDIENTS



For the biscuit base:

200 g digestive biscuits (or graham crackers)
80 g unsalted butter, melted

For the cheesecake filling:

600 g cream cheese, softened
150 g granulated sugar
3 large eggs
200 g sour cream (or thick yogurt)
2 tablespoons lemon juice (about 1–2 lemons)
Zest of 2 lemons
1 teaspoon vanilla extract
A pinch of salt

METHOD



- 1 Prepare the base.** Crush the biscuits and mix with melted butter. Press into a lined loaf pan and chill while you make the filling.
- 2 Make the filling.** Beat cream cheese and sugar until smooth. Add eggs one at a time, mixing gently. Stir in sour cream, lemon juice, lemon zest, vanilla and a pinch of salt until well combined.
- 3 Pour and bake.** Pour the filling over the base and smooth the top.
- 4 Bake at 160°C (320°F) for 45–55 minutes, or until the center is just set with a slight wobble.**
- 5 Cool completely, then chill for at least 4 hours (or overnight) before slicing.**



SMALL
PLEASURES
LEAD TO
BIG CHANGES



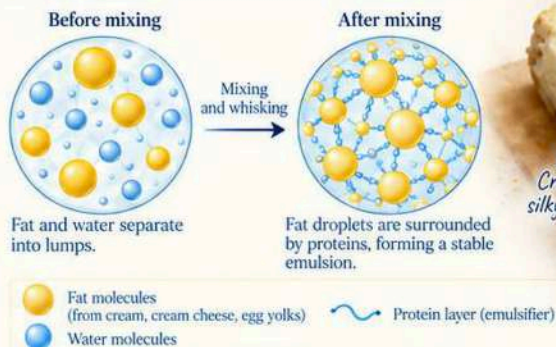
FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

The Physics of Lemon Cheesecake

IMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

1 Emulsion Creates a Smooth Texture

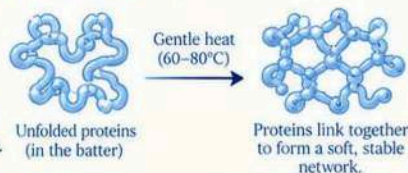
CREAM CHEESE, EGGS, AND FAT FORM A STABLE EMULSION THAT TRAPS WATER, GIVING CHEESECAKE ITS CREAMY, VELVETY TEXTURE.



Creamy texture, bright flavor, and a little science make lemon cheesecake unforgettable.

2 Dairy Proteins Build Structure

EGG PROTEINS SLOWLY UNFOLD AND LINK TOGETHER WHEN HEATED, WHILE CREAM CHEESE PROTEINS ADD RICHNESS, CREATING A SOFT, STABLE FILLING WITHOUT CURDLING.



Why low and slow?



Gentle, steady heat gives proteins time to unfold and link without squeezing out water, keeping the filling creamy and smooth instead of grainy or curdled.

3 Acid Brightens Flavor and Balances Richness

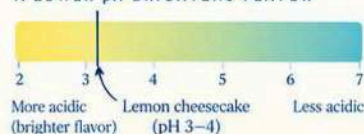
LEMON JUICE ADDS ACIDITY, WHICH BRIGHTENS FLAVOR AND AFFECTS HOW PROTEINS BEHAVE. LEMON ZEST ADDS AROMATIC OILS FOR A FRESH, COMPLEX TASTE.



ACID DOES THREE THINGS:

- 1 Enhances flavor and balances sweetness.
- 2 Helps proteins set into a tender, creamy texture (rather than rubbery).
- 3 Works with aromatic oils from the zest to create a bright, fresh taste.

A LOWER pH BRIGHTENS FLAVOR



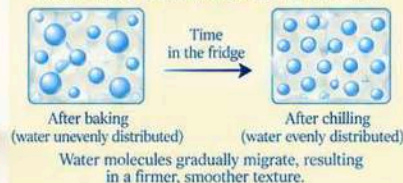
A little acid makes a big difference.

4 Chilling, Diffusion, and Firmness

COOLING ALLOWS THE PROTEIN NETWORK TO STRENGTHEN, AND MOISTURE DISTRIBUTES EVENLY THROUGHOUT. TIME IN THE REFRIGERATOR GIVES THE CHEESECAKE ITS FINAL FIRM, SLICEABLE TEXTURE.



MOISTURE EVENS OUT AS IT CHILLS



IN THE KITCHEN — THE TAKEAWAY



- ✓ Mix gently to incorporate air without overbeating.
- ✓ Bake or heat gently to set the filling without curdling.
- ✓ Avoid overbaking, which can cause cracks or a grainy texture.
- ✓ Chill fully before slicing for the best texture and clean slices.

Good science makes life a little sweeter.

MAY

Delicacy

May is a reminder that the most beautiful things often take time. Like macarons, delicacy is born from patience, precision and care — a balance of simple ingredients transformed into something extraordinary. In a busy world, May invites us to slow down, notice the small details, and savor the sweetness in the process.

*Small treats.
Brighter days.
A more delicate you.*



From my kitchen ♥



SWEETER
MOMENTS
A BRIGHTER
YOU



*Patience
creates
beautiful
things*



INGREDIENTS

For the macaron shells:

100 g almond flour (finely ground)
180 g powdered sugar
100 g egg whites (about 3 large eggs),
at room temperature
100 g granulated sugar
A pinch of salt
½ teaspoon vanilla extract (optional)
A few drops of green food coloring or
matcha powder (optional, for color)

For the filling (matcha buttercream):

100 g unsalted butter, softened
200 g powdered sugar
1–2 teaspoons matcha powder (to taste)
1–2 tablespoons heavy cream or milk
A pinch of salt

METHOD

- 1 Prepare and sift.** Line two baking sheets with parchment paper. Sift the almond flour and powdered sugar together and set aside.
- 2 Make the meringue.** In a clean, dry bowl, beat the egg whites and salt on medium speed until foamy. Gradually add the granulated sugar and beat until stiff, glossy peaks form. Add vanilla and food coloring or matcha (if using).
- 3 Macaronage.** Gently fold the dry ingredients into the meringue in 3 additions. Keep folding until the batter flows like lava and forms a ribbon when lifted.
- 4 Pipe and rest.** Pipe small, even circles onto the prepared baking sheets. Tap firmly on the counter to release air bubbles. Let rest for 30–60 minutes, until a skin forms and they are not sticky.
- 5 Bake.** Bake at 150°C (300°F) for 16–18 minutes. Let cool completely on the baking sheet.
- 6 Make the filling.** Beat butter until creamy. Add powdered sugar, matcha, cream, and a pinch of salt. Beat until smooth.
- 7 Assemble.** Pipe the filling onto half of the shells and sandwich with the other half. Chill for at least hours for the best texture.

DELICATE
THINGS
MAKE LIFE
SWEETER



GOOD FOOD
A BRIGHTER YEAR

The Physics of Macarons

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

1 Meringue Foam Creates Structure

WHIPPED EGG WHITES TRAP AIR IN A NETWORK OF PROTEINS, AND SUGAR STABILIZES THE FOAM, GIVING MACARONS THEIR LIFT AND STRUCTURE.

Before whipping



Egg white proteins are mostly unfolded in liquid form.

After whipping



Proteins unfold and surround air bubbles, forming a stable foam. Sugar strengthens the bubble walls.

● = Egg white protein

● = Air bubble



Stable meringue is glossy, smooth, and holds soft peaks (or stiff peaks).

2 Macaronage Controls the Batter Flow

FOLDING (MACARONAGE) DEFLATES THE MERINGUE JUST ENOUGH TO CREATE A SMOOTH, FLOWING BATTER. THE RIGHT CONSISTENCY ALLOWS THE COOKIES TO SPREAD INTO ROUNDS WITHOUT LOSING THEIR STRUCTURE.



Under-mixed

Batter is too thick and won't spread. Shells may be lumpy with pointed tops.



Just right

Batter flows slowly in a thick ribbon, smoothing out to a round disc in 10–20 seconds.



Over-mixed

Batter is too thin, spreads too much, and can lead to flat shells and weak structure.



The ribbon test: Lift the spatula and let the batter fall. It should flow like thick lava and slowly disappear into the surface in about 10–20 seconds.



3 Resting Forms a Skin

AFTER PIPING, THE BATTER RESTS SO A THIN SKIN FORMS ON THE SURFACE. THIS SKIN HELPS CREATE FEET DURING BAKING AND GIVES SMOOTH, SHINY TOPS.



Right after piping

Surface is wet and sticky.



After resting

A thin skin forms. The surface is dry to the touch and no longer sticks to your finger.

The skin does three things:

- 1 Prevents the top from cracking as the macarons expand.
- 2 Helps feet form by directing expansion at the base.
- 3 Creates a smooth, shiny surface.

Pat gently — if it doesn't stick, it's ready!

A delicate shell, a tender center, and a little science make macarons magical.

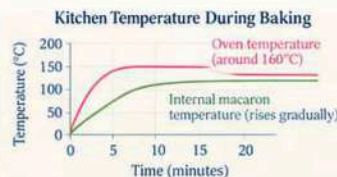


Real batter, from my kitchen (before baking)

Same batter, real results! These are my actual macarons before baking, just like the ones in this guide.

4 Baking Builds Feet and Sets the Texture

HEAT DRIES THE SURFACE, EXPANDS THE AIR AND STEAM INSIDE, AND SETS THE PROTEIN AND STARCH STRUCTURE. THIS CREATES THE SIGNATURE "FEET" AND THE CONTRAST BETWEEN A CRISP SHELL AND A CHEWY INTERIOR.



What happens inside the oven?

1 Early baking



Air and steam expand, lifting the shell and creating feet.

2 Continued baking



The shell sets and dries, trapping the structure.

3 Fully baked



Crisp shell, chewy interior, and defined feet.



IN THE KITCHEN THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Whip to a stable, glossy meringue.
- ✓ Fold gently until the batter flows like thick lava.
- ✓ Rest until a skin forms and the surface is no longer sticky.
- ✓ Bake at the right temperature, and let them cool completely.
- ✓ Be patient — a little science makes a big difference!

Small details. Big rewards.



JUNE

Lightness

June is a celebration of lightness — longer days, softer breezes, and a brighter, kinder rhythm to life. As the season opens up, we're invited to let go of what feels heavy and welcome more ease, joy and simplicity. This chiffon cake is a little slice of that feeling: airy, gentle and deliciously light, a reminder that good things can be simple and uplifting.

*Lighter moments.
Sweeter days.
That's June.* ♥

INGREDIENTS

For the chiffon cake:

- 5 large eggs, separated (about 280 g)
- 100 g granulated sugar (for egg yolks)
- 80 ml vegetable oil (e.g. sunflower or canola)
- 120 ml milk
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- 170 g cake flour (or plain flour, sifted)
- 1 teaspoon baking powder
- ¼ teaspoon salt
- 100 g granulated sugar (for egg whites)
- ½ teaspoon cream of tartar (or 1 teaspoon lemon juice)



From my kitchen ♥



LIGHTER
DAYS
BRIGHTER
POSSIBILITIES
A KINDER YOU



*Good
food
brings
brighter
days* ♥

METHOD

- 1** Prepare the pan. Line a 20 cm (8-inch) square baking pan with parchment paper. Do not grease the pan (chiffon cake needs to cling to the sides).
- 2** Mix the yolk mixture. In a large bowl, whisk together egg yolks, sugar (100 g), oil, milk and vanilla until well combined. Sift in the cake flour, baking powder and salt. Whisk until smooth.
- 3** Whip the egg whites. In a clean bowl, beat egg whites with cream of tartar on medium speed until foamy. Gradually add the remaining sugar (100 g) and beat until soft peaks form (not stiff).
- 4** Combine. Gently fold one-third of the meringue into the yolk mixture to lighten it, then fold in the rest, being careful not to deflate the batter.
- 5** Pour and bake. Pour the batter into the prepared pan and smooth the top. Bake at 160°C (320°F) for 30–35 minutes, or until the top is golden and a skewer comes out clean.
- 6** Cool and serve. Let the cake cool in the pan for 10 minutes, then lift out using the parchment paper. Cool completely before slicing. Enjoy as is, or with a light dusting of icing sugar.



SIMPLE
PLEASURES
MAKE A
BRIGHTER LIFE



FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

The Physics of Chiffon Cake

LIGHT INGREDIENTS. BIG AIR. A REMARKABLY SOFT CAKE.

1 Whipped Egg Whites Trap Air

WHISKING INCORPORATES AIR, CREATING A FOAM OF TINY BUBBLES. PROTEINS UNFOLD AND FORM A STABLE NETWORK AROUND THE AIR, GIVING STRUCTURE.

Before whipping

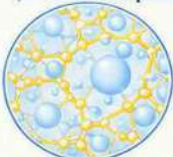


Liquid egg white with proteins in compact form.

Air bubble

Whisking incorporates air

After whipping (soft to medium peaks)



Unfolded proteins surround air bubbles, forming a stable foam that gives the cake its lift.

Egg white protein (unfolded)



Light, airy, and delicately sweet

Tender, cloud-like crumb

Air, structure, and a gentle touch come together to create chiffon cake's feathery crumb and delicate, cloud-like texture.



My real chiffon cake (from my kitchen!)

Fresh from the oven — light, golden, and beautifully risen.

2 Air Incorporation and Stability

THE WHIPPED EGG WHITE FOAM IS FOLDED INTO THE YOLK MIXTURE. CAREFUL, GENTLE FOLDING KEEPS THE AIR BUBBLES INTACT, PRESERVING VOLUME.



FOLDING TECHNIQUE MATTERS



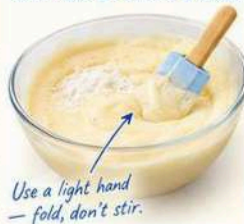
Overmixing deflates the foam, resulting in a dense cake.



Gentle folding keeps small air bubbles, resulting in a light texture.

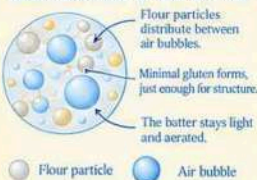
3 Gentle Flour Incorporation

FLOUR ADDS STRUCTURE, BUT TOO MUCH MIXING DEVELOPS GLUTEN, WHICH CAN DEFLATE THE FOAM. GENTLE FOLDING DISTRIBUTES FLOUR EVENLY WHILE KEEPING THE BATTER AIRY.



Use a light hand — fold, don't stir.

WHAT HAPPENS IN THE BATTER



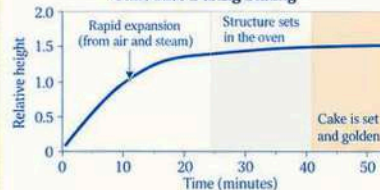
Flour particle

Air bubble

4 Baking Expansion Lifts the Cake

AS THE CAKE BAKES, EXPANDED AIR, STEAM, AND GASES INCREASE IN VOLUME. HEAT SETS THE PROTEIN AND STARCH STRUCTURE, LOCKING IN THE AIR BUBBLES.

Cake Rise During Baking



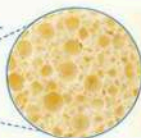
Heat expands the air and steam, then sets the structure, giving chiffon cake its tall, soft, and stable form.

5 Soft Crumb, Set Structure

THE RESULT IS A CAKE WITH A FINE, EVEN AIR CELL STRUCTURE — INCREDIBLY SOFT, YET STABLE ENOUGH TO HOLD ITS SHAPE.



Thin, set surface
Fine, uniform air cells create a soft, tender crumb.
Moist and airy interior
Light golden bottom



A CLOSER LOOK

Many small air cells create chiffon cake's signature light, soft, and springy texture.

IN THE KITCHEN
THE TAKEAWAY



- ✓ Whip egg whites to soft/medium peaks for a stable foam.
- ✓ Fold gently to keep the air bubbles.
- ✓ Avoid overmixing, which deflates the batter and develops gluten.
- ✓ Bake at a moderate temperature to allow full, even rise.
- ✓ Cool in the pan (or on a rack) to set the structure.
- ✓ Enjoy a cake that's light, airy, and irresistibly soft!

A little air makes a big happiness.



JULY

Calm

July invites us to slow down. In the middle of a busy, sun-filled season, there is beauty in stillness — in a warm scone, a quiet kitchen, and a moment just for you. Matcha, with its earthy depth and steady presence, reminds us to find calm in the everyday. These matcha cream-cheese scones are soft yet tender, with a gentle contrast between the rich, creamy center and the lightly golden top — a small reminder that balance makes life sweeter.

*Slower days.
Warmer moments.
A calmer you.*



INGREDIENTS

For the scone dough:

- 250 g all-purpose flour
- 25 g cornstarch
- 50 g granulated sugar
- 2 tbsp matcha powder (culinary grade)
- 1 tbsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 100 g cold unsalted butter, cubed
- 120 g cold heavy cream (or whole milk)
- 1 large egg
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

For the cream cheese filling:

- 200 g cream cheese, softened
- 30 g granulated sugar
- 1 tbsp sour cream (or thick yogurt)
- 1/2 tsp vanilla extract



Soft, earthy, and so good ♥

METHOD

1

Make the filling. In a bowl, beat cream cheese, sugar, sour cream and vanilla until smooth. Set aside.

2

Prepare the dough. In a large bowl, whisk together flour, cornstarch, matcha powder, baking powder and salt. Cut in the cold butter until the mixture resembles coarse crumbs. In a separate bowl, whisk together the cream, egg and vanilla. Add to the dry ingredients and mix gently until just combined. The dough will be soft and slightly sticky.

3

Shape. Divide the dough into 14–16 pieces (about 40–45 g each) and gently shape into rough balls or squares. Make a dent in the center of each piece.

4

Fill. Add about 1–2 teaspoons of cream cheese filling into each indentation.

5

Bake. Place on a parchment-lined baking tray and bake at 190°C (375°F) for 18–22 minutes, or until the tops are lightly golden.

6

Cool. Let the scones cool for at least 10 minutes before serving. Best enjoyed warm or at room temperature.

GOOD
FOOD
BRINGS
CALM DAYS



*A
quieter
mind
a brighter
day*



SMALL
RITUALS
CREATE
A CALMER LIFE



FOOD FOR A KINDER YOU

The Physics of Matcha Scones

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

Earthy flavor, tender layers, and a little science make matcha scones irresistible.

1 Cold Butter Creates a Tender, Flaky Crumb

COLD BUTTER MELTS IN THE OVEN, LEAVING STEAM POCKETS THAT CREATE LAYERS AND A TENDER TEXTURE.

Cold butter in dough

During baking

After baking



Cubed, cold butter is coated in flour, keeping it solid and separate in the dough.



As the scone bakes, butter melts into steam, leaving pockets in the dough.



The steam pockets create layers and a light, tender crumb.



Keep it cold!

Cold butter (4–10°C) melts at just the right time, creating lift without making the dough greasy.

Golden top, tender crumb

Same recipe. Real results.

Creamy filling

Vibrant matcha color



My matcha scones (before baking)

Baking turns simple ingredients into something special.

2 Limited Gluten Development Keeps Scones Tender

SCONES NEED JUST ENOUGH STRUCTURE TO HOLD TOGETHER. MINIMAL MIXING PREVENTS EXCESS GLUTEN, KEEPING THE TEXTURE TENDER AND CAKE-LIKE.

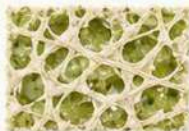
Less mixing (ideal)



Flour particles coated in fat
Limited gluten strands

Short gluten strands give structure but keep the crumb tender.

Overmixing (tougher texture)



More gluten strands develop, creating a chewier, bread-like texture.

TIPS FOR A TENDER SCONES

- 1 Mix just until the dough comes together.
- 2 Keep butter cold.
- 3 Handle the dough gently and avoid overworking.

A little restraint leads to a softer bite.

3 Steam Lift Creates Height and Flakiness

MOISTURE TURNS TO STEAM IN THE HOT OVEN, EXPANDING AND PUSHING APART THE LAYERS FOR A TALL, FLAKY SCONES.

Before baking

During baking

After baking



Compact dough with cold butter and moisture.

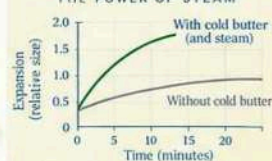


Steam expands, pushing layers apart.



A taller scone with distinct layers and a flaky texture.

THE POWER OF STEAM



Steam from melted butter and water creates more lift and a lighter texture.

4 The Filling Stays Creamy (Without Melting Away)

A STABLE FILLING HOLDS ITS SHAPE BY USING EGG PROTEINS AND FAT, WHICH SET GENTLY AS IT BAKES, STAYING CREAMY INSIDE THE SCONES.

WHY THE FILLING WORKS

- 1 Egg proteins slowly coagulate, setting the filling.
- 2 Fat (cream cheese) keeps it creamy and prevents it from drying out.
- 3 The scone's structure holds the filling in place.
It bakes into a creamy center, not a runny mess.



TEMPERATURE MATTERS

Just right (Creamy and set)



Bake at a moderate temperature (around 180°C) for a creamy, stable filling.

Too hot or too long (Filling can leak)



— IN THE KITCHEN —
THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Use cold butter and keep the dough cold.
- ✓ Mix gently to avoid excess gluten.
- ✓ Steam from butter and moisture creates lift and flaky layers.
- ✓ Egg and cream cheese help the filling set and stay creamy.
- ✓ Bake at a moderate temperature for the best texture.
- ✓ A little science turns simple ingredients into something special.

Good bakes make brighter days.



AUGUST

Precision

August reminds us that beauty often lives in the details. Precision turns simple ingredients into something extraordinary — the right temperature, the right time, the right balance. These French egg tarts are a quiet lesson in patience and care, where every step matters, and the reward is a custard that's silky, golden and unforgettable.

*Same simple things.
Even better results.*



From my kitchen ♥



SMALL
DETAILS
BRIGHTER
DAYS
A KINDER YOU



*Good food
brings
brighter
days*



INGREDIENTS



For the pastry (pâte sucrée):

250 g plain flour (all-purpose flour)
125 g unsalted butter, cold and cubed
80 g icing sugar (confectioners' sugar)
1 large egg yolk
1–2 tablespoons cold water
A pinch of salt

For the egg custard filling:

500 ml whole milk
200 ml double cream (heavy cream)
5 large egg yolks
100 g granulated sugar
1 tablespoon cornflour (cornstarch)
1 teaspoon vanilla extract (or 1 vanilla bean)
A pinch of salt

METHOD



1

Make the pastry. In a bowl, rub the butter into the flour and icing sugar until it resembles fine crumbs. Add the egg yolk, salt and cold water, and bring together into a dough. Chill for at least 30 minutes.

2

Prepare the tart cases. Roll out the chilled dough, cut into rounds and line a muffin or tart tin. Prick the base and chill for 15 minutes. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 12–15 minutes, until just set. Let cool slightly.

3

Make the custard. In a saucepan, gently heat the milk and cream until just simmering. In a bowl, whisk together egg yolks, sugar, cornflour, vanilla and salt.

4

Temper the eggs. Slowly pour the warm milk into the egg mixture, whisking constantly. Return to the pan and cook gently, stirring, until slightly thickened (it should coat the back of a spoon). Do not boil.

5

Fill and bake. Strain the custard into the cooled pastry cases. Bake at 200°C (400°F) for 18–22 minutes, or until the tops are beautifully caramelised like in the photo.

6

Cool and enjoy. Let the tarts cool completely before serving. Best enjoyed slightly warm or at room temperature.



PATIENCE
CREATES
EXTRAORDINARY
THINGS



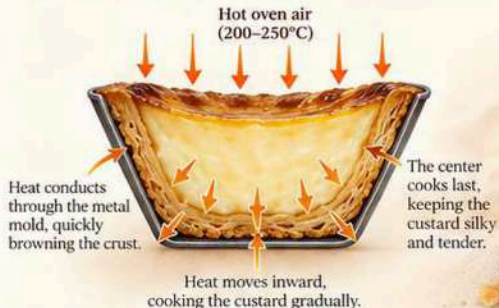
FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

The Physics of French Egg Tarts

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

1 Heat Transfer Bakes from the Outside In

HEAT FLOWS FROM THE HOT OVEN AIR THROUGH THE METAL TART MOLD, BAKING THE CRUST FIRST AND GENTLY COOKING THE CUSTARD FROM THE EDGES TOWARD THE CENTER.



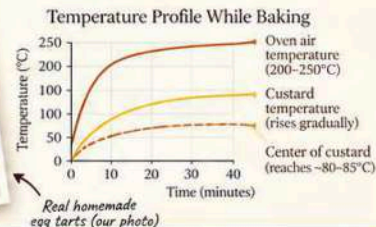
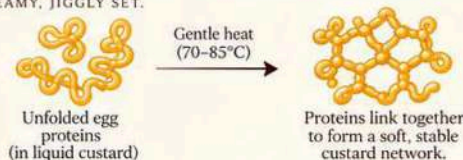
Caramelized top with rich, complex flavor

Buttery, crisp pastry shell

Silky, creamy custard

2 Protein Coagulation Sets the Custard

EGG PROTEINS SLOWLY UNFOLD AND LINK TOGETHER WHEN HEATED, TRANSFORMING THE LIQUID CUSTARD INTO A SOFT, CREAMY, JIGGLY SET.



The custard sets gently, preventing curdling and keeping a silky texture.

3 Caramelization and Browning Create the Signature Top

HIGH HEAT DRIVES CARAMELIZATION OF SUGARS AND MAILLARD REACTIONS AT THE SURFACE, FORMING THE TART'S BEAUTIFUL GOLDEN-BROWN BLOTCHES AND RICH, COMPLEX FLAVOR.



These reactions create the tart's signature mottled surface — sweet, creamy, and slightly roasted in flavor.

SURFACE COLOR DEVELOPS OVER TIME



Higher oven temperatures create more caramelization, giving the classic dark, mottled top.

4 Texture Contrast Makes It Irresistible

THE HIGH FAT CONTENT CREATES A FLAKY, CRISP SHELL, WHILE THE CUSTARD SETS INTO A SMOOTH, SILKY TEXTURE — A PERFECT CONTRAST IN EVERY BITE.



THE MICROSTRUCTURE TELLS THE STORY



IN THE KITCHEN THE TAKEAWAY

- ☑ Use a hot oven (200–250°C) to brown the top and crisp the shell.
- ☑ Let the custard reach 80–85°C to set (but avoid overbaking).
- ☑ A metal tart mold helps conduct heat for a crisp crust.
- ☑ Look for a golden, mottled top — that's flavor!
- ☑ Cool slightly before eating to enjoy the perfect texture contrast.

Good science makes life a little sweeter.



SEPTEMBER

Restraint

September teaches us the beauty of restraint. As the heat fades and the air turns crisp, osmanthus blooms quietly, filling the world with a subtle, lingering fragrance rather than shouting for attention. This osmanthus mung bean cake is a humble delight — simple ingredients, refined flavors, and a gentle sweetness that reminds us that less can be more.

*A quieter season,
A sweeter you.*



Freshly made at home ♥



SIMPLE
INGREDIENTS
A CALMER MIND
A KINDER YOU



INGREDIENTS

For the mung bean paste:

300 g dried hulled mung beans
80 g rock sugar (or granulated sugar)
20 g unsalted butter
A pinch of salt

Other ingredients:

2–3 tablespoons dried osmanthus flowers
(edible, food grade)

Optional:

1 tablespoon honey (for extra fragrance)
A little water (as needed)

METHOD

- 1 Prepare the mung beans.** Rinse the mung beans and soak for at least 4 hours (or overnight). Drain and steam until very soft, about 25–30 minutes.
- 2 Make the paste.** Blend the steamed mung beans while warm until smooth. Transfer to a pan, add sugar, butter and a pinch of salt. Cook over low heat, stirring constantly, until the paste is thick and non-sticky. Stir in most of the osmanthus flowers (reserve a little for garnish) and honey if using. Let it cool slightly.
- 3 Shape.** Press the mung bean paste into a lined tray or mold, about 1.5–2 cm thick. Smooth the top.
- 4 Set.** Chill in the refrigerator for at least 2 hours until firm.
- 5 Slice and garnish.** Cut into squares or use a mold. Sprinkle with the remaining osmanthus flowers.

DISCIPLINE
IN SMALL
THINGS
LEADS TO
A BRIGHTER
TOMORROW



FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

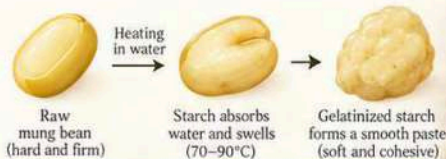
The Physics of Osmanthus Mung Bean Cake

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. GENTLE SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

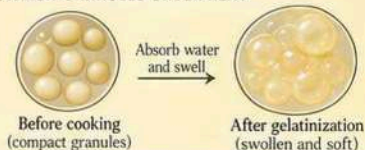
A humble bean, a fragrant bloom, and the quiet power of physics turn simple ingredients into a delicate, unforgettable treat.

1 Starch Gelatinization Creates a Smooth Paste

WHEN MUNG BEANS ARE COOKED, THEIR STARCH GRANULES ABSORB WATER, SWELL AND GELATINIZE, TURNING FROM FIRM PARTICLES INTO A SMOOTH, MELLOW PASTE — THE FOUNDATION OF A DELICATE TEXTURE.



STARCH GRANULES UNDER HEAT



3 Compression and Shaping Create the Signature Form

PRESSING THE THICKENED PASTE INTO A MOLD OR TRAY REMOVES AIR POCKETS, MAKES THE TEXTURE UNIFORM, AND GIVES THE CAKE ITS CLEAN, COMPACT SHAPE. ONCE CHILLED, IT HOLDS ITS FORM AND CAN BE CUT INTO NEAT SQUARES.



Compression brings the particles closer together, creating a smooth, cohesive texture and beautiful, clean edges.

THE AROMA JOURNEY



Gentle heat preserves the delicate aroma, which is released gradually as you eat.

4 Flavor Release and Texture Perception

DELICATE OSMANTHUS FLOWERS RELEASE VOLATILE AROMA COMPOUNDS THAT REST ON THE SURFACE, WHILE THE MUNG BEAN BASE PROVIDES A DENSE, SMOOTH CRUMB. THE COMBINATION CREATES A LAYERED EXPERIENCE — FRAGRANT ON TOP, MELT-IN-THE-MOUTH WITHIN.



THE TEXTURE UP CLOSE



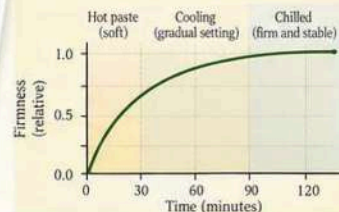
A light fragrance on top, a smooth sweetness within. ♥

2 Moisture Reduction Helps It Set

AS THE PASTE COOKS, EXCESS WATER EVAPORATES, CONCENTRATING THE STARCH, SUGARS AND NATURAL BINDERS. UPON COOLING, THE THICKENED PASTE SETS INTO A FIRM YET TENDER CAKE THAT HOLDS ITS SHAPE.



COOLING HELPS THE PASTE SET



As the temperature drops, starch chains form a gentle network, trapping water and giving the cake structure.

IN THE KITCHEN THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Cook the mung beans until very soft for a smooth paste.
- ✓ Simmer and reduce moisture until the paste is thick and holds shape.
- ✓ Press firmly and chill to get clean, beautiful squares.
- ✓ Let the osmanthus rest on top — its fragrance completes the experience.

Small moments make sweeter days. ♥

OCTOBER

Playfulness

October reminds us to make room for joy. As the air turns crisp and the days glow with golden light, color finds its way into the ordinary — in small celebrations, sweet treats, and moments shared. These homemade donuts are a playful reminder that happiness can be simple: a warm bite, a cheerful sprinkle, and a little time to enjoy what makes life sweeter.

*A little sweetness,
A lighter heart.*



Homemade with love ♥



SMALL JOYS
TURN
ORDINARY DAYS
GOLDEN



*Color,
comfort,
brighter
days*



INGREDIENTS

500 g plain flour (all-purpose flour)
7 g instant yeast
60 g sugar
1 egg (large)
250 ml warm milk (about 35–40°C)
60 g unsalted butter (softened)
1/2 teaspoon salt

For frying:

Vegetable oil (enough for deep frying)

For topping:

Glaze (simple sugar glaze or chocolate glaze)
Sprinkles, sliced almonds, sesame seeds
(or any favorite toppings)

METHOD

1

Make the dough. In a large bowl, mix flour, yeast, sugar, egg, warm milk, butter and salt until a shaggy dough forms.

2

Knead the dough. Turn onto a floured surface and knead for about 8–10 minutes, until smooth and elastic.

3

First rise. Place the dough in a lightly oiled bowl, cover and let it rise in a warm place for 1–1½ hours, or until doubled in size.

4

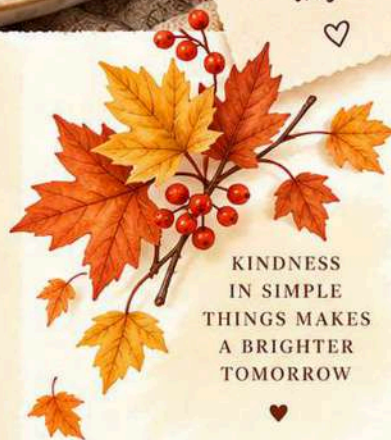
Shape the donuts. Roll out the dough to about 1 cm thick. Cut into rounds and use a smaller cutter (or bottle cap) to make holes. Place on a floured tray.

5

Second rise. Cover and let the shaped donuts rise for 30–45 minutes, until puffy.

6

Fry and glaze. Heat oil to 170–180°C (340–350°F). Fry the donuts for 1–2 minutes per side until golden brown. Drain on paper towels and let cool slightly. Dip in glaze and add your favorite toppings.



KINDNESS
IN SIMPLE
THINGS MAKES
A BRIGHTER
TOMORROW



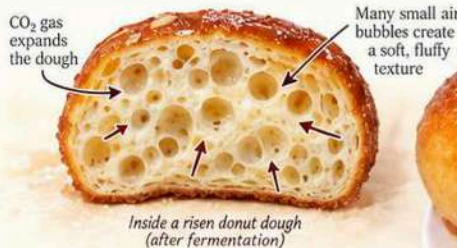
FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

The Physics of Donuts

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

1 Yeast Fermentation Creates the Lift

YEAST FEASTS ON SUGARS, RELEASING CARBON DIOXIDE GAS THAT GETS TRAPPED IN THE DOUGH. THESE TINY BUBBLES EXPAND, MAKING THE DONUTS LIGHT, SOFT, AND AIRY.



Warmer temperatures (25–30°C) help yeast work faster, but patience creates better flavor.



A soft, airy crumb, a golden crust, and a touch of sweetness — science turns a simple dough into something extraordinary.

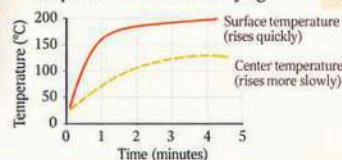
Good food brings brighter days

2 Frying Drives Fast Heat Transfer

HOT OIL QUICKLY TRANSFERS HEAT INTO THE DONUT, COOKING THE OUTSIDE FIRST. AT THE SAME TIME, MOISTURE TURNS TO STEAM, HELPING THE DONUT PUFF UP BEFORE THE INSIDE SETS.



Temperature Profile While Frying



The outside reaches high temperature quickly, while the inside heats gradually.

3 Maillard Browning Creates Irresistible Flavor

THE MAILLARD REACTION BETWEEN SUGARS AND AMINO ACIDS CREATES THE DONUT'S GOLDEN COLOR AND RICH, COMPLEX FLAVORS. HIGH HEAT DRIVES THIS TRANSFORMATION ON THE SURFACE.

Color and flavor develop over time



Heat triggers hundreds of reactions, forming new flavor compounds that make donuts irresistible — nutty, caramel, and slightly toasty.

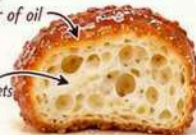


4 Oil Absorption Gives the Perfect Texture

AS THE DONUT COOLS, A SMALL AMOUNT OF OIL REMAINS IN THE SURFACE AND JUST BELOW, GIVING A TENDER CRUMB AND RICH MOUTHFEEL. THE CRUST STAYS CRISPY WHILE THE INSIDE REMAINS SOFT AND MOIST.

Crispy, thin crust with a light layer of oil

Soft, airy crumb with tiny air pockets



THE MICROSTRUCTURE TELLS THE STORY



Crispy crust (defined structure)



Airy crumb (uneven air pockets)

IN THE KITCHEN

THE TAKEAWAY

- ☒ Let yeast do its magic — time creates the fluff.
- ☒ Fry at 170–180°C for a golden crust and tender center.
- ☒ Look for a rich, golden-brown color — that's flavor.
- ☒ A little oil makes a better texture.
- ☒ Share and enjoy — science tastes sweeter together.



Small moments make life a little sweeter.



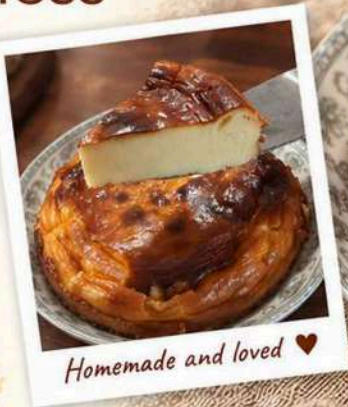


NOVEMBER

Boldness

November invites us to embrace contrast. As the days grow darker, we find beauty in deeper flavors, richer moments, and a bolder sense of self. There is strength in imperfection — in the cracks, the uneven browning, the things that don't have to be perfect to be extraordinary. This Basque cheesecake reminds us that sometimes, the most beautiful things are the ones that take up space.

*Imperfect, warm,
unforgettable.* ♥



Homemade and loved ♥



SMALL
COURAGES
CREATE
BRIGHTER
DAYS



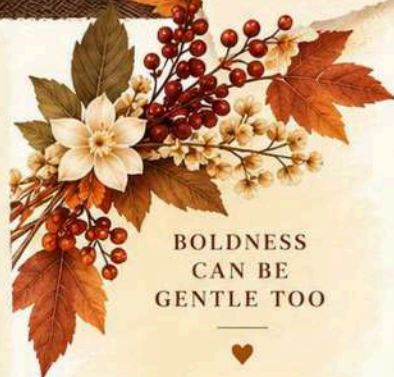
*Colder air,
deeper
flavor,
more me.* ♥

INGREDIENTS

600 g cream cheese
(softened, full-fat)
150 g granulated sugar
4 large eggs
300 ml heavy cream (whipping cream)
1 tablespoon cornflour
(or all-purpose flour)
1 teaspoon vanilla extract
A pinch of salt

METHOD

- 1 Prepare the tin.** Line a 6–7 inch (15–18 cm) round cake tin with baking paper, letting the paper rise well above the sides. No need to grease.
- 2 Make the batter.** In a large bowl, beat the cream cheese until smooth. Add the sugar and mix until combined. Beat in the eggs one at a time, then add the cream, cornflour, vanilla extract and a pinch of salt. Mix until smooth and silky.
- 3 Strain (optional).** For an extra silky texture, pour the batter through a fine sieve into the prepared tin.
- 4 Bake at high heat.** Bake in a preheated oven at 220–250°C (425–480°F) for 25–30 minutes, until the top is deeply browned and almost burnt, while the center still jiggles.
- 5 Cool and chill.** Let the cheesecake cool completely at room temperature, then refrigerate for at least 4 hours (or overnight) before serving. It will set into a creamy, dreamy texture.



BOLDNESS
CAN BE
GENTLE TOO



FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

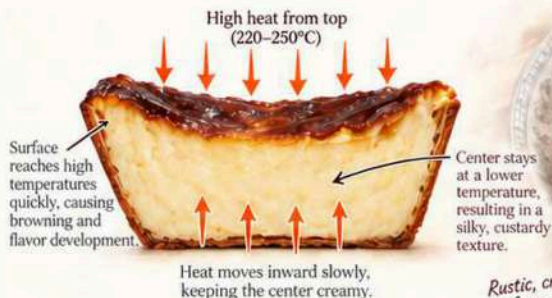
The Physics of Basque Cheesecake

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

A deeply caramelized top, a creamy, custardy center — science turns a humble cheesecake into something extraordinary.

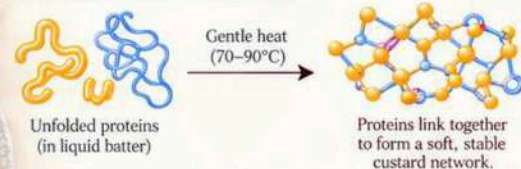
1 A Strong Temperature Gradient Creates a Brownd Top and Creamy Center

HIGH OVEN HEAT RAPIDLY BROWNS THE SURFACE WHILE THE INSIDE BAKES MORE GENTLY, CREATING THE SIGNATURE CONTRAST OF A DARK, CARAMELIZED TOP AND A SOFT, CUSTARDY CENTER.

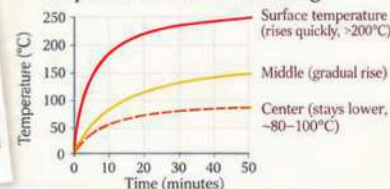


2 Protein Coagulation Sets the Custard

EGG PROTEINS AND MILK PROTEINS UNFOLD AND LINK TOGETHER WHEN HEATED, TRANSFORMING THE LIQUID BATTER INTO A SOFT, CREAMY, JIGGLY-SET CHEESECAKE.



Temperature Profile While Baking



A high temperature difference creates a browned exterior while keeping the inside creamy.

3 Maillard Browning and Caramel-like Flavor Development

HIGH HEAT DRIVES MAILLARD REACTIONS BETWEEN SUGARS AND AMINO ACIDS AT THE SURFACE, CRRATING THE CHEESECAKE'S DEEP BROWN COLOR AND RICH, COMPLEX, CARAMEL-LIKE FLAVORS.



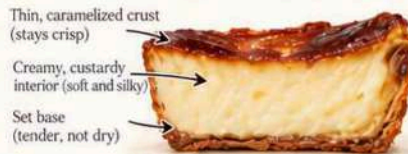
SURFACE COLOR DEVELOPS OVER TIME



Higher oven temperatures and longer baking create more browning, resulting in rich, caramel-like flavor.

4 Cooling and Carryover Setting Preserve the Contrast

AFTER BAKING, THE CHEESECAKE CONTINUES TO SET AS IT COOLS. CARRYOVER HEAT GENTLY FIRMS THE CENTER WHILE THE SURFACE RETAINS ITS THIN, BRONZED CRUST.



THE MICROSTRUCTURE TELLS THE STORY



IN THE KITCHEN THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Use high heat (220–250°C) to create a deeply browned top.
- ✓ Let the center bake gently — it should still wobble slightly.
- ✓ Carryover heat continues to set the cheesecake as it cools.
- ✓ Cool completely for the best texture and flavor contrast.
- ✓ Simple ingredients, big results — trust the process.

Good food makes life a little sweeter.



DECEMBER

Warmth

December reminds us that the warmest moments are often the simplest. As the year draws to a close, we find joy in a cozy kitchen, the comfort of homemade treats, and the happiness of giving. These butter and alpaca cookies are more than just sweets — they are small tokens of care, carrying a little warmth to the people we love.

*Warm hands,
warm kitchen,
warm year.*



INGREDIENTS

120 g unsalted butter (softened)
80 g granulated sugar
1 egg (about 50 g)
220 g all-purpose flour
1 teaspoon vanilla extract
A pinch of salt

Optional:

Powdered sugar (for dusting)

*Simple ingredients
create sweet memories.*



Homemade with love



METHOD

- 1** Cream the butter and sugar. In a large bowl, beat the softened butter and sugar until light and fluffy (about 2–3 minutes).
- 2** Add the wet ingredients. Beat in the egg and vanilla extract, mixing until well combined.
- 3** Mix in the dry ingredients. Sift in the flour and salt, and stir until a soft, smooth dough forms.
- 4** Shape the cookies. Pipe small flower shapes for butter cookies (as in the photo), or roll out the dough and cut out alpaca shapes. Place on a lined baking tray.
- 5** Bake. Bake at 180°C (350°F) for 12–15 minutes, or until the edges are lightly golden. Let cool, then dust with powdered sugar if desired.

SMALL
COOKIES
BIG COMFORT



*Sweetness
shared is
warmth
multiplied.*



KINDER
PEOPLE
MAKE A WARMER
WORLD



FOOD FOR
A BRIGHTER YEAR

The Physics of Butter Cookies & Alpaca Cookies

SIMPLE INGREDIENTS. SWEET SCIENCE. BRIGHTER DAYS.

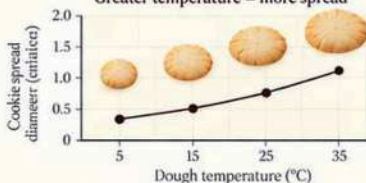
A tender bite,
a crisp edge,
and a little creativity
turn simple dough
into something special.

1 Butter Viscosity Controls Dough Spread

BUTTER SOFTENS AS IT WARMS, BECOMING LESS VISCOUS AND MORE FLUID. WARMER DOUGH SPREADS MORE IN THE OVEN, CREATING THINNER, CRISPIER COOKIES.



Greater temperature = more spread



Warmer dough flows more in the oven, giving a larger, thinner cookie.

Crisp edges, tender center

Adorable shapes make sweet moments brighter

Simple ingredients, extraordinary results

2 Creaming Incorporates Air for Tenderness

BEATING BUTTER AND SUGAR CREATES TINY AIR BUBBLES, WHICH EXPAND IN THE OVEN, GIVING COOKIES A LIGHTER, MORE TENDER TEXTURE.

Under-mixed (denser texture)

Well-creamed (light and tender)



Fewer air bubbles, more compact dough.

Many tiny air bubbles create a lighter texture.

More air in the dough means a more tender, melt-in-your-mouth cookie.

3 Baking Drives Moisture Loss and Sets the Structure

IN THE OVEN, WATER EVAPORATES, BUTTER MELTS, AND STARCHES SET. THE EDGES LOSE MORE MOISTURE AND BROWN FIRST, WHILE THE CENTERS STAY MORE DELICATE.

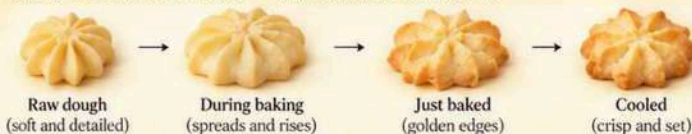
Edges bake faster and lose more moisture, becoming crisp and golden.



Cookie cross-section (real photo)

Center retains a bit more moisture, keeping the cookie tender and delicate.

FROM DOUGH TO BAKED — THE TRANSFORMATION



4 Surface Browning and Decoration Create the Final Appeal

HEAT TRIGGERS MAILLARD REACTIONS, CREATING A GOLDEN COLOR AND RICH, BUTTERY FLAVOR. A DUSTING OF POWDERED SUGAR ADDS BEAUTY, FLAVOR, AND A PERKY FINISH.

Golden-brown edges develop rich flavor through Maillard reactions (~140–165°C)

Piped ridges create more surface area for beautiful browning.

Powdered sugar adds sweetness and a snow-like finish.

Dried osmanthus brings a delicate floral aroma and a touch of elegance.

TWO FRIENDS, SAME DOUGH



Butter Cookie

- ✓ Crisp edges
- ✓ Tender center
- ✓ Classic and elegant



Alpaca Cookie

- ✓ Same delicious dough
- ✓ Fun and creative
- ✓ Brings extra joy

IN THE KITCHEN

THE TAKEAWAY

- ✓ Use cool to room-temperature butter for better control over spread.
- ✓ Cream butter and sugar until light and fluffy to incorporate air.
- ✓ Bake at the right temperature (170–190°C) until the edges are golden.
- ✓ Decorate with powdered sugar or osmanthus for extra flavor and beauty.
- ✓ Simple physics turns everyday ingredients into delightful moments.

Good cookies make life a little sweeter.

References

GOOD QUESTIONS LEAD TO A BRIGHTER KITCHEN

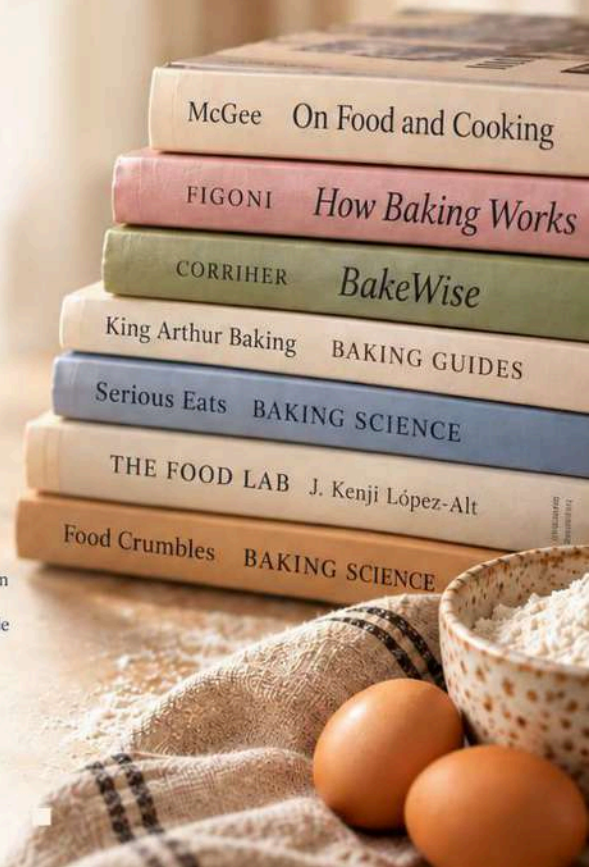
Curiosity
is always
a good
ingredient.

SMALL
LEARNING
MOMENTS
CREATE A
BRIGHTER
TOMORROW

Selected sources that informed the science notes

The monthly pages in this calendar draw on the work of these authors, organizations, and educators. Their research, testing, and clear explanations help us understand the why behind baking, and have been thoughtfully synthesized into simple, visual explanations for student readers.

- 1 Harold McGee**
On Food and Cooking: The Science and Lore of the Kitchen
Scribner, 2004.
A foundational work that explains the science behind everyday cooking and baking, with unmatched depth and clarity.
- 2 Paula Figoni**
How Baking Works: Exploring the Fundamentals of Baking Science
Wiley, 2011.
A clear, approachable guide to the science of baking, with helpful illustrations and practical insights.
- 3 Shirley O. Corriher**
BakeWise: The Hows and Whys of Successful Baking
Scribner, 2008.
A practical, in-depth exploration of baking science, with a focus on ingredients, techniques, and troubleshooting.
- 4 King Arthur Baking**
Baking Guides
King Arthur Baking Company. Website: kingarthurbaking.com
Trusted, thoroughly tested guides, articles, and recipes that explain the science and practice of baking in an accessible way.
- 5 Serious Eats**
Baking Science Articles
Serious Eats. Website: seriouseats.com
In-depth, research-driven articles that explore the science behind baking techniques and ingredients.
- 6 The Food Lab**
The Food Lab: Better Home Cooking Through Science
J. Kenji López-Alt.
W. W. Norton, 2015.
A rigorous, engaging exploration of the science of cooking and baking, with practical applications for home cooks.
- 7 Food Crumbles**
Baking Science Essays
Food Crumbles. Website: foodcrumbles.com
Clear, thoughtful essays that break down the science of baking and make it accessible and enjoyable.



The more we learn
about food, the more
we appreciate its magic.

THIS CALENDAR BRINGS TOGETHER
TRUSTED KNOWLEDGE AND EVERYDAY JOY
— BECAUSE UNDERSTANDING FOOD
HELPS US ALL BAKE A BRIGHTER TOMORROW.

GOOD FOOD. BRIGHTER DAYS. A KINDER YOU.

Good
baking
begins
with
confidence
♥



Baking Measurement & Temperature Guide



SIMPLE CONVERSIONS. CONFIDENT BAKING. BRIGHTER DAYS.

Measure well.
Bake with joy.
Brighter days
are homemade.
♥

SMALL
DETAILS
BRING
SWEETER
DAYS



1 Common Metric to Volume Conversions

EVERYDAY INGREDIENTS. EVERYDAY BAKES.

Ingredient	Metric (grams/ml)	US Cup/Volume (approx.)
 All-purpose flour	120 g	1 cup
	30 g	1/4 cup
	150 g	1 1/4 cups
 Granulated sugar	200 g	1 cup
	50 g	1/4 cup
	100 g	1/2 cup
 Unsalted butter	113 g	1/2 cup (1 stick)
	227 g	1 cup (2 sticks)
	57 g	1/4 cup
 Milk (whole)	240 ml	1 cup
	120 ml	1/2 cup
	60 ml	1/4 cup

2 Oven Temperature Conversions

FROM RECIPE TO REAL LIFE.

°C	°F	Description
120	250	Very low (gentle)
140	275	Low
150	300	Low
160	325	Moderate low
170	340	Moderate
180	350	Moderate (most baking)
190	375	Moderate hot
200	400	Hot
220	425	Hot
230	450	Very hot
240	475	Very hot

Different ovens can vary.
An oven thermometer helps ensure
accurate results. ♥



3 Key Baking Reference Temperatures

KNOW THE NUMBERS. BAKE BETTER.

	Butter softening	16–20°C (60–68°F)	Soft enough to press with a finger, still cool. Ideal for creaming.
	Custard setting	80–85°C (176–185°F)	Egg custards set gently at this range. They should coat the back of a spoon.
	Yeast activity	24–30°C (75–86°F)	Ideal temperature for yeast to activate and rise effectively.
	Chocolate melting	45–50°C (113–122°F)	Melts smoothly without seizing. Use a gentle heat (or bain-marie).
	Maillard browning	140–165°C (284–329°F)	Where sugars and proteins react to create golden color and rich flavor.
	Caramelization	160–180°C (320–356°F)	Sugar melts and turns amber, developing complex flavors.

4 Quick Tips for Baking Success

SMALL HABITS. BIGGER RESULTS.



Weigh for accuracy

Grams are more precise
than cups, especially
for flour. Use a digital
kitchen scale when
possible.



Always preheat

Give your oven time
to reach the right
temperature. Most bakes
need at least 15–20
minutes of preheating
for even results.



Use an oven thermometer

Ovens can be off by
10–25°C (20–50°F).
A simple thermometer
ensures your bakes
cook at the right
temperature.

Good
measurements
lead to great
memories.
♥



BAKING
A BRIGHTER
TOMORROW
♥

About the Author

Amy Hu

STUDENT • RESEARCHER • BAKER

Hi, I'm Amy! I'm a student, researcher, and baker who is endlessly curious about how making things can turn invisible ideas into visible experiences. Whether in the kitchen, the lab, or a design sketchbook, I'm drawn to the moment when a concept leaves the page and becomes something you can see, touch, and share.

This book grows out of home baking, curiosity, and a desire to make learning warm, personal, and shareable. My hope is that these recipes inspire you to slow down, notice the small details, and find joy in the process — just as I do.

Good food.
Brighter days.
Together.

A SWEETER TOMORROW



Small things
can make
a brighter
tomorrow.

Through this book, I hope to share not just recipes, but a way of seeing the world — where curiosity, creativity, and kindness come together. May your kitchen be a place of exploration, joy, and connection, and may we all keep making a brighter, more delicious tomorrow.

- More curiosity.
- More kindness.
- More good food.



WHAT INSPIRES ME



Physics

I'm fascinated by how the universe works, from the tiniest particles to everyday phenomena.



Food

I love how simple ingredients can create extraordinary experiences through science and care.



Design

I enjoy finding beauty in thoughtful details and creating things that feel both useful and meaningful.



Building

I'm excited to work on projects that connect science with care — for people, for communities, and for a brighter tomorrow.

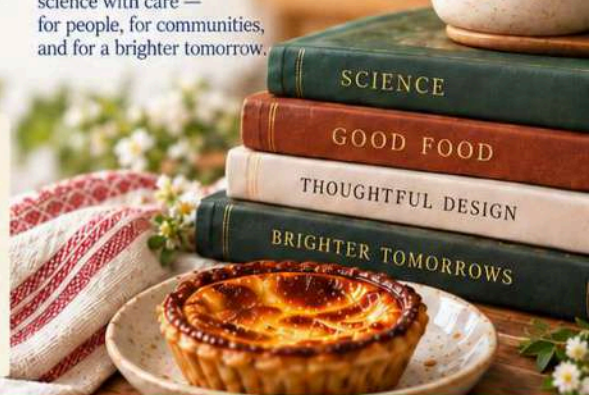
SIMPLE
INGREDIENTS
BRIGHTER DAYS
A KINDER YOU



Curiosity
in the oven.
A kinder
world on
the table.



Ideas
ingredients
people
brighter days.



Acknowledgements

*"This book is the result of many hands, kind words,
and shared moments around the table."*

To my family,

Thank you for your unconditional love, encouragement, and for always believing in my curiosity — whether it led me to the kitchen, the lab, or a new adventure. You have tasted countless experiments, cheered me on through both successes and failures, and taught me that food is not just nourishment, but a way of caring.

To my teachers and mentors,

Thank you for opening my mind to the beauty of science, for challenging me to ask "why," and for showing me that curiosity can be a lifelong ingredient. Your guidance helped me see that precision and creativity are not opposites, but partners in something extraordinary.

To my friends,

Thank you for the late-night baking sessions, the honest feedback, the laughter, and for always showing up — whether to taste a new creation, offer a fresh perspective, or simply keep me company when things did not go as planned.

To everyone who has encouraged and supported me,

From taste-testers and fellow students to online communities, readers, and strangers who share the same love for good food and big questions — thank you. Your interest, kind messages, and enthusiasm mean more than you know.

And to you, the reader,

Thank you for picking up this book. May these pages bring a little more curiosity, a little more kindness, and a little more joy to your kitchen and your days. ♥

*"Good food is never
made alone."*



To all who have been part
of this journey —
thank you.



*More curious people
A kinder world
Better food*



*Thank you
for being here.* ♥

*Same
ingredients.
A brighter
tomorrow.* ♥



*Good
people
make
good food
possible.* ♥

Photography/ Production Note

Real kitchen photos. Gentle edits. Honest baking.

All of the food photographs in this book come from my real kitchen practice. These are actual bakes made, photographed and enjoyed at home — from soft breads and sweet buns to simple cookies, using everyday ingredients and tools. They capture genuine moments in the baking process, with all the warmth, texture and little imperfections that make homemade food so special.

*Real ingredients.
Real moments.
A sweeter everyday life.*



Production Note

This book brings together recipes, the science and physics behind baking, personal reflections, and thoughtful editorial design. The photographs are my own, taken in a home kitchen, and may be lightly adjusted for brightness, contrast and color consistency to ensure clear and appealing reproduction in print, while staying faithful to the original food.

All pages were designed for a compact landscape print format, so you can enjoy this book easily at home or on the go.



Homemade happiness ♥



From my kitchen to this book ♥



Simple bakes, real joy ♥

GOOD
FOOD
BRIGHTER
DAYS



*Baked
at home
with love
— Amy Hu*



SAME KITCHEN. BRIGHTER DAYS.



FOOD • KNOWLEDGE • REFLECTION • A KINDER YOU

SMALL
THINGS
MAKE A
BRIGHTER
TOMORROW



Until Next Time

Same curiosity. More good food.

Thank you for baking, exploring, and thinking a little more deeply about the small things with me.

May your kitchen always be a place of curiosity, creativity, and connection — where simple ingredients can lead to extraordinary experiences, and where every experiment, whether it rises perfectly or not, still makes the day a little brighter.

*Good food.
Brighter days.
A kinder tomorrow.*

♡
— Amy

*Same
kitchen.
Different
stories.*

*Still more
to bake.*
♡

*A sweeter
tomorrow
is always
possible.*
♡

*Good
Food
Brighter
Days*
♡

RECIPES

SCIENCE

A BRIGHTER YOU

SWEETER TOMORROW

